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**Slug:** FACTCHECK WETLANDS

**Head:** # Fact check: Minnesota's wetland losses are real, but not recent

**Dek:** *A viral post pins the state's long-run wetland loss on the last 25 years. Nearly all of it happened decades earlier, as wet prairie was ditched and tiled for farming.*

**Rating:** **False**

By Owen Brandt
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About 480 words, plus sources

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Minnesota has lost roughly half of the wetlands it had before settlement. In parts of the south and west, where shallow prairie potholes once dotted the land, the losses top 90 percent. That damage is real, and it is large. Nearly all of it happened between the 1850s and the 1980s.

**The claim:** A post shared widely on social media says "Minnesota lost half its wetlands since 2000." Several conservation groups have passed it along.

**Where the number comes from:** The "half" figure is not new. Minnesota newspapers were printing it in the 1980s, and it meant then what it means now: the share of the state's original wetlands lost since settlement. A U.S. Fish and Wildlife Service study of wetland losses from colonial times to the mid-1980s put Minnesota's at 42 percent. State estimates that count the original acreage differently come closer to half.

**How it happened:** Mostly by drainage, for farming. Starting in the late 1800s, farmers and county ditch systems drained wet prairie and shallow lakes so the land could be plowed, and buried tile lines carried the water away under the fields. The north, with its peat bogs and wooded swamps, was never easy to farm and kept most of its wetlands. The south and west, the state's best cropland, lost most of theirs.

The draining slowed as the rules changed. The federal Clean Water Act began requiring permits to fill many wetlands in the 1970s. The 1985 farm bill's "Swampbuster" provision cut off federal farm benefits to growers who drained wetlands to plant crops. Minnesota's Wetland Conservation Act of 1991 set a goal of no net loss and requires most wetlands that are drained or filled to be replaced.

**What has happened since 2000:** The state has been measuring. In 2006 the Minnesota Department of Natural Resources started a wetland status and trends monitoring program. It reads

aerial photos of thousands of randomly chosen plots, each a square mile, and goes back to the same plots every three years to estimate how much wetland the state has gained and lost.

Each three-year cycle has shown net change of a fraction of a percent statewide, some cycles slightly up and some slightly down. None comes anywhere near a loss of half.

Losing half since 2000 would mean draining or filling millions of acres in about 25 years. The DNR's monitoring covers most of that stretch, and it shows a statewide total that has barely moved. It doesn't reach back to 2000, but by then the state's no-net-loss law was nearly a decade old and the big drainage era was long over.

**Rating: False.** Minnesota's wetland losses are serious, but they are not recent. The post took a figure that sums up more than a century of drainage and pinned it on the last 25 years. Roughly half since settlement holds up. Half since 2000 does not.

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**SOURCES**

1. Minnesota Department of Natural Resources, Wetland Status and Trends Monitoring Program: statewide wetland quantity reports, from the 2006 to 2008 baseline through the 2018 to 2020 cycle.
2. U.S. Fish and Wildlife Service, Wetlands Losses in the United States, 1780s to 1980s (1990): state-by-state loss estimates.
3. Minnesota Board of Water and Soil Resources: Wetland Conservation Act program summaries, including the no-net-loss goal and replacement requirements.
4. Federal wetland rules: Clean Water Act Section 404 permits; wetland conservation (Swampbuster) provisions of the Food Security Act of 1985.
5. Newspapers.com archive search, Minnesota newspapers, 1980s: drainage coverage citing the "half" estimate.
6. The social media post being checked, as shared by several conservation groups.